Hand of an Angel, Tears of the Lost

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/46427086.

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Teen And Up Audiences

Archive Warning:
Major Character Death

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She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

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Alternate Universe - Canon Divergence, Weird Whispering Woods headcanons, Weird Runestone headcanons, Major Character Injury, Suicidal Ideation, No editors we die with courage, It's my party and I can Momgella if I want, Hurt/Comfort, Finally some comfort in this mess, Forceful sedation in a medical context, Angst, Feral Behavior, Narrative fun with tenses

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Part 6 of Witch's Apprentice AU

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by genVicron

Summary

Grief is a powerful anchor.

Angella knows it well.

Catra stops running at last.

Notes

This one's a lot more self-indulgent than the others, so I've had to embrace the cringe to make myself post it.

See the end of the work for more notes

The Whispers come back; weak, so much weaker than they had been before. Formless, indistinct, when before they used to hiss and sharpen in tune with her.

She doesn't understand. She's dead, everything gone numb and floating like a wound that's hurt so much for so long that she can't do anything other than shut it out.

Why have the Whispers come back? Why can't they just let her die? Why can't she just float in the dark, where she doesn't have to think or *feel* anymore?

It should sting, that Adora isn't in the dark with her, but the feeling is difficult to hold onto. Not that she tries. She's so tired of hurting. If death is just endless numbness, she thinks she can be okay with that. She doesn't have much of a choice in the matter.

But the Whispers are still *there.*

They don't make words anymore- or her mind isn't aligned right to *hear* the words anymore, or there had never *been* words, just what was left of her thoughts echoing and building in a beast's head- but, slowly, she starts to understand. Her stomach hurts, not hunger hurt, blood hurt. Torn and broken and *dying* hurt. She still doesn't feel it, but of course it does, she's been stabbed.

She's supposed to be dead, since when do the Woods talk to dead things- It's gone, Woods Whisper, they stole it. The anchor, the pelt, made of memories, of Her.

The pain in her gut roars back into her awareness, claws itch, fangs ache. The jacket, Ad- *Her* jacket.

Angella had the misfortune of being present when the girl first woke. She'd been halfway through giving Glimmer a thorough dressing down when the magicat had erupted from her sleep in a whirlwind of roaring claws. She'd needed to help hold her back down to be sedated, even as a nurse she had scoured ragged lines into the shoulder of fussed at the stitches and IVs the girl had almost torn from their places in her mad dash towards the door.

Or at least, Angella had thought it was for the door. As she slowly drifted back off, spellwild aggression fading into a desperation that made a lingering something in Angella's chest ache more than the claws currently buried in her arm could hope to match, her eyes were locked on something and Angella let her gaze follow to the chair the filthy rags she'd been wrapped in were piled on.

The rags, and a worn red jacket.

Glimmer had the awareness to look properly chastened once the girl was settled back onto an infirmary cot- the frantic energy settling into slow, sickly shivering- and Angella could turn her attention back to her daughter to demand further details while another healer tended to her arm.

They don’t let her wake up again, no matter how much wild defiance the Whispers try to pump into her. She must be far from the Woods, they can’t even feed her enough to push out her thoughts right anymore, just keep her half-awake even while the cloying- binding, bound, *ordered,* ***false,*** Woods Whisper- stillness forces her quiet and calm.

She’s already losing what she’d seen in the drugged out smear; pastel light, strong, willowy arms hold her down, pale purple eyes, determination, then surprise, suspicion.

Who is that? The Woods Whisper of moonlight, smooth stone, crowns and tides. Of shining walls, a cage, and dark hair. A loss, a pull, a failure.

Her clothes didn't fit anymore. That was the most notable thing about the weakly shivering girl Glimmer had hurried into Bright Moon's infirmary. The Beast of Thaymore was a poorly documented creature, but sightings dated back almost four years. No one so deep in the grip of the Whispering Woods should have been able to live like that for so long.

And yet, she'd outgrown and worn through her clothes so completely that it was clear the only reason she still wore them at all was because she'd either forgotten how or never thought to remove them. They had certainly no longer offered her any sort of modesty or protection.

And yet, the jacket had been repaired. More than once. The thread of the youngest fixes still bright enough that they couldn't be older than half a year.

She hadn't done the repairs herself, Glimmer claimed; she'd sought out help for it. Another thing that should have been impossible for one so lost.

Stories of anchors helping to fend off the Woods' influence were rare, and those that held them always sought to escape that wild pull, but they existed. Heirlooms, scents, pursuing lovers; *memories,* too strong for the Whispers to blot out. And Angella could only think of one kind of anchor that would draw someone to stay in the Whispering Woods' feral oblivion instead of escaping, that the girl would care for while the very shirt on her back fell to tatters.

The same kind that made Angella keep her husband's study clean. The same kind that had seen her standing on the edge of the Woods herself, thirteen years past, before the Moonstone's warm tide had gently swelled around her, pulled away the Whispers, and pushed her back to her daughter's side.

The drug weans off slow, and she wakes before she can move, limbs heavy with sleep and unnaturally unwound tension. Soon, Woods Whisper, get loose, free, fight, bite, **break.**

A growl starts in her chest; take back what they stole, it's Hers, they can't have it, she needs it. A fading piece of her awareness curses the growl for taking the element of surprise away, but she's

not predator now, she's **trapped.** Trapped beast is found, Woods Whisper, stealth doesn't beat trap, power beats trap.

Her claws twitch, defiant strength rushing through her, flashes of green and brown and *alive* waking tired fur. Her eyes snap open and instead of another obstacle, her treasure hangs in front of her.

The world freezes, the drug flushing out letting her mind wake again as she surges up, snatching it to clutch Her jacket close to her chest. Woods Whisper rage through her, energy pinging off her bones, but she can't tell what they mean anymore, she's so far from them, and she has what she wants.

She has Her, all that's left of Her.

She buries her face in the collar, softened by age and wear. She knows it's been too long for any of Her scent to linger, but it hits her hard this time, too far from the Woods for them to mute the blow with Hunt or Rush or Rage. Even sleep feels far away now.

She shudders, tries to take a gasp, but the pain in her gut flares so hard it chokes off, hard to breathe, she can't breathe.

"Leave us," someone's saying something, stern voice, Commander. Not talking to her, doesn't matter, but the words make sense in her head, not even Lonnie's had lined up quite

right with the Woods all around. “We don't need gawkers right now.” The voice softens, “I will be fine, Glimmer.”

Catra risks a glance up, breathe shallow, keep pain from flaring too high.

Purple eyes, wary eyes, sad eyes. Knows that look.

She runs, she runs so hard and so long that the dust doesn’t even stick to her fur anymore. She doesn’t know where she is, just that Ador- that Ad- she clutches the jacket tighter, claws poking holes in it she can’t bring herself to care about. ***She’s*** *gone.* ***She’s*** *gone, and all she had done- could do- was run.*

She can’t even cry anymore. What’s wrong- what’s so ***broken*** *- in her that she can’t cry for Her? She looks down, there’s a puddle at her feet.*

She knows that look.

The girl looked up at her, teeth bared in a snarl that slipped with each unsteady, shivering breath she took. The only steady part of her was her grip on the jacket; Angella had been right, which meant this might just work.

“Hello,” she started, voice low to keep from startling the poor thing, “can you understand me?” The girl made a sound, a low

rasp, her lips twitching like she couldn't quite remember how they worked.

Angella gave her an accepting nod, slowly lowering herself into a chair beside the girl's bed. She tensed, some of the wild fervor of the Woods flashing through her eyes, but Angella kept her motions slow, bringing up a hand clenched around something small and precious to her own chest.

"Angella," she offered, and the girl blinked, brow furrowing. Angella hesitated a moment, the old wound she had to poke at for this to work ached in her chest, keeping her fingers tight around the little thing even as she lowered her hand. She took a slow breath and relaxed her fingers, revealing a small, rough clay square, the childish wings pressed into it facing the girl. "...Micah."

The girl's eyes widened, the ominous flicker of the Woods fled as understanding bloomed across her face. Her mismatched eyes flicked from the memento up to Angella's face and she seemed to shrink, her fur laying back down flat as her shallow breaths came louder.

"Cah-... Kuh…" long neglected words tried to slip past the girl's lips and she set her jaw, her eyes starting to glimmer with tears she blinked away as quickly as they came. She looked away, staring at the sheets with a determined glower, "Cat…" one of her hands released the jacket, coming up to tap her chest the way Angella had her own, "Catra."

Her breath hitched again and her eyes squeezed shut, tears coming too heavy for her to blink away, staining the fur of her face. She clutched the jacket with both hands again, lifting it slightly, "Adora," she bit out, starting to shake even more. "Adora," she repeated, her voice choking out with wet emotion now instead of disuse as she pulled the jacket back in against her chest. She twitched, curling around the battered cloth, the wound in her gut clearly painful, but unable to stop her from sobbing now, " *Adora.* "

Catra hasn't said either name in so long, hasn't even been able to get herself to think them, but Adora's name spills from her lips like water. Every breath shoots pain through her chest but she barely cares, it's nothing to the wrenching sobs that shake her, release and agony with every chant of Her- of Adora's name.

Warmth slips around her back, the Woods don't know this feeling, they can't Whisper in tune with it, so even though they call her to strike at the unfamiliar touch she can't make herself care enough to do it. Soft light shines through her eyelids as another touch joins the first and Catra finds herself pulled into a soft embrace by someone so much taller than she is.

An older instinct flinches at the touch of the only grown-up who she can remember holding her. But instead of the sharp, wrathful crush of fingers around her arms, around her *throat,* this touch is gentle and steady and everything no adult has ever been for Catra before. And she melts into it, turning her head to bury her face against the slim shoulder Angella offers her.

The girl- Catra, cried against her, the feverish heat of her making Angella frown in concern even as she whispered comforting

nonsense sounds to her. She felt so thin in Angella's arms, all knobby joints and starved, lean flesh.

How old was she? Angella peered down at Catra, her brow furrowed as she gently tightened her grip on the weeping girl. She couldn't have been much older than Glimmer; so small, her neglected voice cracking with the last lingering remnants of puberty.

Four years, an even younger girl than this had held enough grief to not only drive her into the Whispering Woods grip, but to force her to survive *four years*- maybe even longer before she found the village- of the feral, callous treatment they visited on their victims. Angella had the feeling this cry was a long time coming.

So she held Catra against her chest, cradling her softly as she cried herself out. Angella veiled her in her wings, keeping the rest of the world at bay for her. One hand lifted, hesitating for a moment before she began to gently work fingers through the matted mane on Catra's head. Raising an especially rambunctious toddler who had complained at even the slightest snag on her hair had long since taught her how to make the motions soothing rather than painful no matter the snarl- or how many twigs Glimmer had needed fished out- even after so long.

Catra whimpered in her arms, one hand leaving the jacket to wrap an arm around Angella, claws pricking at her back as Catra tried to pull her closer, still repeating her grief's name, Adora.

"I know. I have you," she murmured to the girl, noting how the last bit of poised tension left her at that.

It took a long while for Catra to go quiet, longer still for her to fall asleep again, letting Angella lower her back to her cot, looking over her stitches to make sure nothing had torn.

She glanced to the door, a rueful smile tugging at her face at the shadow pacing on the other side of it. "Glimmer," she called softly, watching the shadow jolt to a stop. The door slipped open just enough for her daughter's anxious eyes to peer inside. "Fetch some water, please. And ice, we may need to bring down her fever."

Glimmer nodded, an all too familiar determined glint to her eye as she set off to help Angella care for this poor child she'd brought to them. She let her face soften as she gathered blankets; Glimmer really was so much like her dearest Micah.

End Notes

Come say hi at Makuta's Chronicle or genVicron!

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